Sharing examples like these with people unfamiliar with the principles of FI typically elicits one of two polar opposite effects. Some see frugality as a path to reclaiming their lives, while others think of how much sacrifice FI requires and decide it's not worth the effort.

Some people become highly motivated and start making changes immediately. Joel and Alexis of the blog *Financial 180* are a great example of this. Within a year of discovering the idea of FI, they were saving over 80 percent of their income while working as engineers. Neither made a six-figure income. An even more extreme example is a couple named Paige and Sam. They are listeners of the *ChooseFI* podcast who shared their story of saving toward FI while living in the high-cost city of Los Angeles. Both work in the LA arts community, and their combined income is well under $100,000. People working regular jobs as teachers, in military service, and as blue-collar laborers who apply these lessons become the next generation of "The Millionaires Next Door."

At the same time, others dismiss the idea of FI as requiring extreme frugality or even living in poverty. Todd Tresidder operates the financial education website, *Financial Mentor.* He calls this traditional path to achieve FI "Lean FIRE." He characterizes it as